



Stigma and Discrimination

The lives of people with mental health conditions are often plagued by stigma as well as discrimination. **Stigma is a negative stereotype.** Stigma is a reality for many people with a mental illness, and they report that how others judge them is one of their greatest barriers to a complete and satisfying life.

Stigma differs from discrimination. **Discrimination is unfair treatment due to a person's identity**, which includes race, ancestry, place of origin, colour, ethnic origin, citizenship, creed, sex, sexual orientation, gender identity, gender expression, age, marital status, family status or disability, including mental disorder. Acts of discrimination can be overt or take the form of systemic (covert) discrimination. Under the *Ontario Human Rights Code*, every person has a right to equal treatment with respect to services, goods and facilities, without discrimination due to the identities listed above.

Stigma is the negative stereotype and discrimination is the behaviour that results from this negative stereotype. Often, individuals with a mental illness are faced with multiple, intersecting layers of discrimination as a result of their mental illness and their identity. For example, a woman with a mental illness may experience discrimination due to sexism as well as her illness, and a racialized individual may experience discrimination due to racism in addition to their mental illness. In addition, living with discrimination can have a negative impact on mental health.

Media influence on public attitudes

Many studies have found that media and the entertainment industry play a key role in shaping public opinions about mental health and illness. People with mental health conditions are often depicted as dangerous, violent and unpredictable. News stories that sensationalize violent acts by a person with a mental health condition are typically featured as headline news; while there are fewer articles that feature stories of recovery or positive news concerning similar individuals. Entertainment frequently features negative images and stereotypes about mental health conditions, and these portrayals have been strongly linked to the development of fears and misunderstanding.

Impact of negative public attitudes

There are significant consequences to the public misperceptions and fears. Stereotypes about mental health conditions have been used to justify bullying. Some individuals have been denied adequate housing, health insurance and jobs due to their history of mental illness. Due to the stigma associated with the illness, many people have found that they lose their





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in reducing stigma and breaking down negative stereotypes associated with substance use disorders. By using non-stigmatizing language, those who are experiencing challenges may experience fewer barriers to accessing supports.

The following guide includes some suggestions of person-first language in mental health:

Common / outdated terms

Person-first language

Mental health *disorders*

Mental health *issues, conditions or illnesses*

Individuals “*struggling*” or “*suffering from*”

or *having* a mental illness, mental health condition or issue

Individuals *living with* mental illnesses, mental health condition or issue

***Committed Suicide*, “*suicided*”,**

***Died by* suicide**

or *successful* / *unsuccessful* suicide

***Attempted* suicide**

Mental illnesses

A mental illness (or specify specific disorder, rather than generalize by using the term “mental illness” to capture all mental illnesses.)

***Mentally ill* person**

Someone who *has* a mental illness.

Someone who *is* bipolar

Someone who *is living with* bipolar disorder.

Patient* / *Client

People *with lived experience* or *individuals we serve*

He/she *has a* substance use condition.





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Use the STOP criteria to recognize attitudes and actions that support the stigma of mental health conditions. It's easy, just ask yourself if what you hear:

- **Stereotypes** people with mental health conditions (that is, assumes they are all alike rather than individuals)?
- **Trivializes** or belittles people with mental health conditions and/or the condition itself?
- **Offends** people with mental health conditions by insulting them?
- **Patronizes** people with mental health conditions by treating them as if they were not as good as other people?

If you see something in the media which does not pass the STOP criteria, speak up! Call or write to the writer or publisher of the newspaper, magazine or book; the radio, TV or movie producer; or the advertiser who used words which add to the misunderstanding of mental illness. Help them realize how their words affect people with mental health conditions.

Start with yourself. Be thoughtful about your own choice of words. Use accurate and sensitive words when talking about people with mental health conditions.



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